

VCU319687 Tinajero, Lucille vs. Sequoia Medical Services, L.P. et al

County: tulare

Division: Civil Law and Motion

Department: 9

Hearing date: 2026-08-31

Motion: Motion for Final Approval of Class Action and PAGA Settlement

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Re: Tinajero, Lucille vs. Sequoia Medical Services, L.P. et al

Case No.: VCU319687

Date: August 31, 2026

Time: 8:30 A.M.

Dept. 9-The Honorable Nathan D. Ide

Motion: Motion for Final Approval of Class Action and PAGA Settlement

Tentative Ruling: To grant the motion; to set the hearing as to compliance with the settlement agreement as to distribution for April 5, 2027, 8:30 am, Dept. 9.

Facts and Analysis

Plaintiff's motion for final approval of class action and PAGA settlement, attorneys' fees, costs, enhancement award, LWDA payment and class certification for settlement purposes came on for hearing on April 20, 2026. The Court finds and rules as follows:

On August 3, 2026, the settlement administrator Apex Class Action, LLC, through its Case Manager, filed a declaration detailing the following events.

On February 25, 2026, the administrator received a mailing list of 46 potential class members from Defendant's counsel with names, contact information, social security numbers and relevant employment information.

On March 9, 2026, after the administrator processed the names through the National Change of Address Database and updated the list with any updated addresses located, the administrator sent class notice by mail to 46 members. Six (6) notices were returned and updated addresses for five (5) were obtained and notices were mailed. Therefore, one (1) notice has been deemed undeliverable.

Class members had sixty (60) days, until April 8, 2026 to submit objections, disputes and/or requests for exclusions. Zero (0) requests for exclusion and zero (0) valid objections have been received from class members. Therefore, all 46 Class Members or 100% of the Class will participate in the settlement.

The court presumes the settlement is fair and reasonable given (a) that it was reached through arms-length bargaining at mediation, (b) that there was sufficient time for investigation and discovery since commencement of litigation (c) class counsel have particularized experience with the claims at issue in the case, and (d) there appear to be no disputes or objections. (*Dunk v. Ford Motor Co.* (1996) 48 Cal.App.4th 1794, 1802.)

A net settlement amount of \$60,293.56 is available to pay to the class members in accordance with the terms of settlement. The highest class portion to be paid is approximately \$3,710.02, the lowest class portion to be paid is approximately \$34.51, and the average class portion to be paid is approximately \$1,114.13.

The Court believes basic information about the nature and magnitude of the claims in question and the basis for concluding that the consideration being paid for the release of those claims represents a reasonable compromise under the circumstances, in accordance with *Kullar v. Foot Locker Retail, Inc.* (2008) 168 Cal.App.4th 116, 133. This case involved extensive informal discovery and investigation of disputed claims, including review and analysis by Plaintiff's expert. The settlement avoids significant risks and delay that would result from further litigation of the case, which would include, amongst other matters, certification proceedings, trial, and the possibility of further delay and cost resulting from appeals.

Class counsel has provided an updated declaration in support of the requests for attorney fees representing 33.3% of the of the gross settlement fund of \$150,000 or \$50,000.

Attorney Akhavan indicates 73 hours at the rate of \$825 per hour, creating a base lodestar of \$60,225 (Declaration of Akhavan ¶12.)

Barahmand Law Group indicates 53.8 hours at the rate of \$420 per hour, creating a base lodestar of \$22,865. (Declaration of Barahmand ¶18.)

Counsel has additionally provided sufficient cost information indicating actual costs incurred in the amount of \$10,956.44 in fees. (Declaration of Barahmand ¶25.) The Court notes that this motion and the proposed order seeks approval of up to \$20,000 in fees. The Court, on final approval, approves the actually incurred fees.

The Court believes the requested attorney fees and costs appear reasonable under the circumstances. Additionally, counsel has provided a sufficient declaration to demonstrate adequate previous experience with class actions to further support the reasonableness of the award.

The settlement administrator has provided, in the declaration describing the work it has performed on the case, a value of services totaling \$ 3,750. The Court believes the amount requested as compensation for the administrator appears reasonable.

The settlement agreement designates California Controller's Office Unclaimed Property Division, with an identification of the Participating Class Member to whom the funds belong, in accordance with Code of Civil Procedure section 384.

The Court previously approved a representative payment of \$5,000 and finds that the requested enhancement payment is appropriate under the circumstances.

Finally, the Court confirms its conditional certification of the settlement class. The Court finds no significant events have occurred that would cause it to change its prior determination that the settlement class met all requirements under Code of Civil Procedure section 382 for certification for settlement purposes at the time it granted Plaintiff's motion for preliminary approval.

On review of the declarations and pleadings submitted, the Court finds, given the established presumption that the settlement is fair and reasonable under the circumstances of this case, and, particularly, given the absence of any objection or opposition following the class notice, that the settlement is fair and reasonable and that the motion for final approval should be, and is hereby, granted.

Therefore, the following deductions from the gross settlement of \$150,000 are approved as follows:

Approved Court Approved Attorney Fees:

\$50,000.00

Approved Incurred Attorney Costs:

\$10,956.44

Approved Enhancement Payment to Plaintiff :

\$5,000.00

Approved Settlement Administrator Costs

\$3,750.00

Approved PAGA Payment (LWDA and Aggrieved Employees)

\$20,000.00

Approved Net Settlement Amount

\$60,293.56

Therefore, the Court grants the motion. The Court sets the hearing as to compliance with the settlement agreement as to distribution for April 5, 2027, 8:30 am, Dept. 9.

If no one requests oral argument, under Code of Civil Procedure section 1019.5(a) and California Rules of Court, rule 3.1312(a), no further written order is necessary. The minute order adopting this tentative ruling will become the order of the court and service by the clerk will constitute notice of the order. Court reporters are usually not available for law and motion matters in the civil division. The parties and counsel must provide their own reporter if they want a transcript of the proceedings.